Enslavement, Racism, Policing and Prisons

45 key historical facts stated in Jeff Kisling's blog posts on this topic, each checked against an outside source.

Enslavement, Racism, Policing and Prisons

The posts tie the history of slavery in the United States (1619, the Thirteenth Amendment's punishment clause and Juneteenth) and racial terror lynching, as documented by the Equal Justice Initiative, to present-day police killings and mass incarceration. They follow Black Lives Matter-era events from Ferguson (2014) to George Floyd and the Chauvin verdict, the militarization of police, Confederate flag and monument removals, and racial-justice organizing in Indianapolis and Des Moines.

45 facts checked against outside sources, 4 of them corrected (the posts had a detail slightly wrong; the corrected version is shown). Each fact lists the source that confirms it and the posts that state it. The wording is a plain summary, not a quotation from the posts.

Facts

1. 1619-08

In late August 1619 (believed to be August 25), about "20 and odd" enslaved Africans arrived at Point Comfort, Virginia, aboard the English privateer White Lion, the first documented arrival of Africans in English-occupied North America.

> ***Note:*** *Posts describe this as the first slave ship to reach what became the United States; the Park Service frames it as the first documented arrival in the English colonies.*

- **Source:** 400 Years of African American History (National Park Service)
- **In the posts:** Juneteenth (2019-06-20); Forcing the government to do their part in removing statues to white supremacy (2020-07-05)

2. 1865-06-19

On June 19, 1865, Union Major General Gordon Granger issued General Order No. 3 in Galveston, Texas, announcing that all enslaved people in Texas were free, more than two years after the Emancipation

Proclamation; the day is commemorated as Juneteenth.

> ***Note:*** *The 2019 post, quoting another source, places the arrival "one day in late June, 1865"; the 2020 post gives the exact date of June 19.*

- **Source:** The Original Juneteenth Document (U.S. National Archives)
- **In the posts:** Juneteenth (2020-06-19); Juneteenth (2019-06-20); “So, let’s get free!” (2020-07-04)

3. 1865-12-06

The Thirteenth Amendment, passed by Congress on January 31, 1865, and ratified on December 6, 1865, abolished slavery and involuntary servitude "except as a punishment for crime whereof the party shall have been duly convicted."

- **Source:** 13th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution: Abolition of Slavery (1865) (U.S. National Archives)
- **In the posts:** Decolonial Journey 13 – Abolition (2025-08-07); Making New Worlds (2021-04-16)

4. 1877–1950

The Equal Justice Initiative has documented more than 4,400 racial terror lynchings of Black people in the United States between Reconstruction and World War II (1877–1950).

- **Source:** Lynching in America: Confronting the Legacy of Racial Terror (Equal Justice Initiative)
- **In the posts:** Nooses (2019-07-18)

5. 1877–1950

The Equal Justice Initiative's Lynching in America research counts roughly 4,000 racial terror lynchings of African Americans in twelve Southern states between 1877 and 1950 (4,075 in its current edition).

> ***Note:*** *The 2016 post rounds the figure to 4,000; EJI's current count for the twelve states is 4,075.*

- **Source:** Lynching in America: Confronting the Legacy of Racial Terror (Equal Justice Initiative)
- **In the posts:** Racial Terrorism (2016-03-07)

6. 1963-05

During Birmingham's Children's Crusade in May 1963, more than 1,000 young marchers were jailed; nearly 1,000 had been jailed by the end of the first day, May 2, and about 4,000 students went to jail between May 2 and May 11.

> ***Note:*** *Counts differ by source and by day: HISTORY.com reports nearly 800 arrests on May 2, while the Zinn Education Project gives almost 1,000 jailed by the end of May 2 and about 4,000 over May 2-11.*

- **Source:** May 2-11, 1963: Children of Birmingham Fill the Jails (Zinn Education Project); Children's Crusade march in Birmingham (HISTORY.com)
- **In the posts:** Civil Disobedience and the Civil Rights Movement (2017-11-15)

7. 1963-09-15

On September 15, 1963, the bombing of the 16th Street Baptist Church in Birmingham, Alabama, killed four girls: Addie Mae Collins, Carol Denise McNair, Cynthia Wesley and Carole Rosamond Robertson.

- **Source:** 16th Street Baptist Church bombing (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Another time of cultural chaos (2020-04-21)

8. 1964-06-21 (corrected)

On June 21, 1964, civil rights workers James Chaney, Andrew Goodman and Michael Schwerner were murdered in Neshoba County, Mississippi, by members of the White Knights of the Ku Klux Klan.

> ***Correction:*** *The 2020 post dates the murders to 1963; they took place on June 21, 1964.*

- **Source:** Murders of Chaney, Goodman, and Schwerner (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Another time of cultural chaos (2020-04-21); Civil Disobedience and the Civil Rights Movement (2017-11-15)

9. 1965-03-07 (corrected)

On March 7, 1965 (Bloody Sunday), state troopers beat marchers who were crossing the Edmund Pettus Bridge in Selma, Alabama, on their way to Montgomery; John Lewis, then 25, led the march and suffered a fractured skull.

> ***Correction:*** *The post describes the march as 'going to Selma'; it set out from Selma toward Montgomery. Lewis was born February 21, 1940.*

- **Source:** Bloody Sunday (1965) (Wikipedia); John Lewis (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Another time of cultural chaos (2020-04-21)

10. 1968-02-08

On February 8, 1968, South Carolina highway patrolmen and a city police officer fired on student protesters at South Carolina State College in Orangeburg, killing Samuel Hammond Jr., Delano Middleton and Henry Smith (the Orangeburg massacre).

- **Source:** Orangeburg massacre (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Another time of cultural chaos (2020-04-21)

11. 1978

By 1978 the American Friends Service Committee's board had adopted a position supporting the abolition of prisons.

- **Source:** Reflecting on AFSC's history in the penal abolition movement (American Friends Service Committee)
- **In the posts:** Making New Worlds (2021-04-16)

12. 1997

The Pentagon's 1033 program, which transfers surplus military equipment to local law enforcement agencies, was created by Section 1033 of the National Defense Authorization Act of 1997.

- **Source:** How Tanks Got to Main Street (Friends Committee on National Legislation); 1033 program (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Ferguson and Militarized Police (2018-08-09)

13. 2010 (corrected)

A 2010 Pew Economic Mobility Project report found that one in 87 working-aged white men was in prison or jail, compared with one in 36 Hispanic men and one in 12 African American men.

> ***Correction:*** *The post states the figures without a source or age group; they come from Pew's 2010 'Collateral Costs' report and refer to working-aged men.*

- **Source:** Collateral Costs: Incarceration's Effect on Economic Mobility (Irish Penal Reform Trust (summary of Pew report)); ABFE Criminal Justice
- **In the posts:** Criminal Justice Reform Bill (2018-12-20)

14. 2013-04

The Moral Mondays movement began in North Carolina in April 2013, led by Rev. William Barber II, then president of the North Carolina NAACP, with civil-disobedience protests at the state legislature; the first, on April 29, 2013, ended in 17 arrests.

- **Source:** Moral Mondays (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Quakers and the Poor People's Campaign (2018-07-06); Our Moral Moment Comes to Congress (2025-04-28); Path of nonviolence (2015-06-26)

15. 2014

Indy10 Black Lives Matter was founded in 2014 by a group of ten strangers who traveled from Indianapolis to Ferguson, Missouri, to protest the police killing of Michael Brown.

> ***Note:*** *The posts add that the group met on social media and took supplies to Ferguson; the source checked does not mention those details.*

- **Source:** 10 Things To Know About Indy10 Black Lives Matter (Indianapolis Monthly)
- **In the posts:** Ferguson and Militarized Police (2018-08-09); KI and North Meadow Friends (2015-10-21)

16. 2014-08-09

Michael Brown, an unarmed 18-year-old Black man, was shot and killed by Ferguson, Missouri, police officer Darren Wilson on August 9, 2014; the heavily militarized police response to the protests that followed drew national attention.

- **Source:** Michael Brown killed by police in Ferguson, Missouri (HISTORY.com)
- **In the posts:** Ferguson and Militarized Police (2018-08-09); Quaker Social Change Ministry at North Meadow Friends (2016-02-02); Making New Worlds (2021-04-16); State Violence (2020-06-13); Silencing Protest (2019-10-07)

17. 2014-11-22 (corrected)

Tamir Rice, a 12-year-old Black boy holding a toy gun, was shot and killed by a Cleveland police officer outside the Cudell Recreation Center on November 22, 2014.

> ***Correction:*** *One post says he was shot "in his front yard"; he was shot at the Cudell Recreation Center in Cleveland.*

- **Source:** Grand jury will not file charges in Tamir Rice death (PBS NewsHour)

- **In the posts:** Racism and Policing (2020-06-05); Proof black lives do not matter (2016-01-03)

18. 2015

In 2015 the Equal Justice Initiative began a project to collect soil from every site where a person was lynched, starting in Alabama, so that the jars could form part of an exhibit on the history of lynching.

- **Source:** EJI Hosts Project to Remember Lynching in Alabama (Equal Justice Initiative)
- **In the posts:** Racial Terrorism (2016-03-07)

19. 2015-01-28

On January 28, 2015, a South Carolina judge vacated the 1961 trespassing convictions of the 'Friendship 9', who were sentenced to 30 days of hard labor after a sit-in at the whites-only lunch counter of McCrory's in Rock Hill.

- **Source:** Judge Throws Out 'Friendship Nine's' Civil Rights-Era Conviction (NPR); Judge exonerates Friendship 9 activists 54 years after arrest (WUWF); Friendship Nine (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Conviction of ‘Friendship 9’ for lunch counter sit-in to be overturned (2015-01-28)

20. 2015-05-18

On May 18, 2015, President Obama's Executive Order 13688 barred transfers of items such as tracked armored vehicles, grenade launchers and large-caliber weapons to police under the 1033 program.

- **Source:** 1033 program (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Ferguson and Militarized Police (2018-08-09)

21. 2015-06-17

On June 17, 2015, a white supremacist gunman killed nine Black worshippers at Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston, South Carolina, among them Rev. DePayne Middleton-Doctor.

- **Source:** Charleston church shooting (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Charleston (2015-06-19); Quakers and Black Lives Matter (2016-07-12); Black Lives have always mattered (2022-02-01)

22. 2015-06-27

On June 27, 2015, activist Brittany "Bree" Newsome climbed the flagpole on the South Carolina State House grounds, took down the Confederate battle flag and was arrested.

- **Source:** Bree Newsome (Wikipedia)

- **In the posts:** The Confederate Flag (2015-07-10)

23. 2015-07-10

After the Charleston church shooting, South Carolina passed a law removing the Confederate flag from the State House grounds, and the flag was taken down for the last time on July 10, 2015.

- **Source:** Charleston church shooting (Wikipedia); Bree Newsome (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** The Confederate Flag (2015-07-10)

24. 2015-12-28

On December 28, 2015, a Cuyahoga County grand jury declined to bring charges against the Cleveland officers involved in the killing of Tamir Rice.

- **Source:** Grand jury will not file charges in Tamir Rice death (PBS NewsHour)
- **In the posts:** Proof black lives do not matter (2016-01-03)

25. 2016-07-28

On July 28, 2016, Rev. William Barber II told the Democratic National Convention in Philadelphia that people are called to be 'the moral defibrillators of our time.'

- **Source:** Rev. William Barber Rattles the Windows, Shakes the DNC Walls (NBC News); NC NAACP president speaks at DNC (Spectrum News)
- **In the posts:** Higher Ground Moral Declaration (2016-08-28)

26. 2017-08-28

On August 28, 2017, the Trump administration lifted the Obama-era limits on giving surplus military equipment to police; Attorney General Jeff Sessions said the restrictions "went too far."

- **Source:** 1033 program (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Ferguson and Militarized Police (2018-08-09)

27. 2018-04-26

The Equal Justice Initiative opened the National Memorial for Peace and Justice, which honors victims of racial terror lynching, and the Legacy Museum in Montgomery, Alabama, on April 26, 2018.

- **Source:** Legacy Museum and National Memorial for Peace and Justice to Open on April 26, 2018 (Equal Justice Initiative)

- **In the posts:** National Memorial for Peace and Justice (2018-04-26); Juneteenth (2019-06-20); Modern-Day Lynchings (2023-01-27)

28. 2018-05

The Poor People's Campaign: A National Call for Moral Revival launched 40 days of protest, including civil disobedience, in about 30 states on Mother's Day weekend in May 2018, inspired by Martin Luther King Jr.'s 1968 Poor People's Campaign.

- **Source:** Poor People's Campaign gears up for Mother's Day launch (Resilience)
- **In the posts:** Poor People's Campaign Launch (2018-05-13)

29. 2018-12-18

On December 18, 2018, the U.S. Senate passed the First Step Act, a bipartisan criminal justice reform bill, by a vote of 87-12; its reforms apply to federal prisons and federal sentencing.

- **Source:** First Step Act (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Criminal Justice Reform Bill (2018-12-20)

30. 2019-08-18

The New York Times Magazine published the 1619 Project in August 2019; the first issue appeared on August 18, 2019.

- **Source:** The 1619 Project (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** NNA, Race and Community Building (2019-08-30)

31. 2020

According to Mapping Police Violence, about 28% of the more than 1,100 people killed by U.S. police in 2020 were Black, although Black people make up about 13% of the U.S. population.

- **Source:** There were only 18 days in 2020 that the police didn't kill somebody, according to police accountability data (Yahoo News)
- **In the posts:** Modern-Day Lynchings (2023-01-27)

32. 2020-03-13

Breonna Taylor was shot and killed by Louisville, Kentucky, police shortly after midnight on March 13, 2020, in her apartment, where she and her boyfriend had been asleep.

- **Source:** Breonna Taylor is killed by police (HISTORY.com)
- **In the posts:** Modern-Day Lynchings (2023-01-27); Standing Rock Stands with #BlackLivesMatter (2020-07-02); What's going on? (2020-06-12)

33. 2020-05

George Floyd died in May 2020 after Minneapolis police officer Derek Chauvin knelt on his neck for 9 minutes and 29 seconds, according to prosecutors, while Floyd was handcuffed and lying down.

> ***Note:*** *Posts give the date as May 25, 2020, and say the officer knelt "more than eight minutes"; prosecutors put the time at 9 minutes 29 seconds.*

- **Source:** Derek Chauvin verdict reached in trial over George Floyd's death (NBC News)
- **In the posts:** Racism and Policing (2020-06-05); Des Moines, Police and Protest (2021-04-09); Time Stood Still (2021-04-21)

34. 2020-05-31

Des Moines Register reporter Andrea Sahouri was pepper-sprayed and arrested on May 31, 2020, while covering a Black Lives Matter protest near Merle Hay Mall in Des Moines; she was acquitted in March 2021.

- **Source:** Reporter pepper-sprayed, arrested amid protests in Des Moines (U.S. Press Freedom Tracker)
- **In the posts:** Racial justice protesters banned from Iowa Capitol in "stunning misuse of power" (2020-10-09)

35. 2020-06-07

On June 7, 2020, protesters in Bristol, England, pulled down the statue of slave trader Edward Colston and pushed it into Bristol Harbour.

- **Source:** Statue of Edward Colston (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Black Lives Matter Statue (2020-07-16)

36. 2020-06-22

On June 22, 2020, the Des Moines City Council voted 7-0 to approve an ordinance meant to end racial profiling by city police.

- **Source:** Des Moines City Council approves racial profiling ordinance (Patch)
- **In the posts:** Des Moines, Police and Protest (2021-04-09)

37. 2020-06-26

On June 26, 2020, President Trump signed an executive order on protecting monuments; the White House fact sheet noted that federal law authorizes up to 10 years in prison for willful injury of federal property.

- **Source:** Fact Sheet: President Donald J. Trump Is Combating Violence and Protecting America's Monuments, Memorials, and Statues (The American Presidency Project (UC Santa Barbara))
- **In the posts:** HEY! Come Get Your Racist Uncle (2020-07-02)

38. 2020-07-01

On July 1, 2020, Des Moines Black Lives Matter protested at the Iowa Capitol to demand that Gov. Kim Reynolds restore voting rights to people with felony convictions by executive order; police arrested at least 17 people, including two juveniles.

- **Source:** Police, Black Lives Matter protesters accuse each other of starting violence at Iowa Capitol (Iowa Public Radio); ACLU of Iowa Files Lawsuit on Behalf of Protesters Banned from Capitol
- **In the posts:** Racial justice protesters banned from Iowa Capitol in “stunning misuse of power” (2020-10-09)

39. 2020-07-04

On July 4, 2020, an Indigenous-led rally at the Iowa State Capitol called for removing the Columbus statue, the Pioneer statue and the Westward mural; the Capitol's Columbus monument was donated to the state in 1938.

- **Source:** Indigenous activists rally at Iowa Capitol (WHO 13); Debate over monuments, mural at Iowa State Capitol (WeAreIowa (WOI)); Monuments and Memorials (2011) (State of Iowa Publications)
- **In the posts:** HEY! Come Get Your Racist Uncle (2020-07-02); Indigenous People’s Day, Des Moines, 2020 (2020-10-13)

40. 2020-10-05

On October 5, 2020, the ACLU of Iowa filed a federal lawsuit for five racial justice protesters banned from the Iowa State Capitol after the July 1 arrests.

- **Source:** ACLU of Iowa Files Lawsuit on Behalf of Protesters Banned from Capitol; Protesters banned from Iowa State Capitol reach settlement in First Amendment lawsuit (Little Village)
- **In the posts:** Racial justice protesters banned from Iowa Capitol in “stunning misuse of power” (2020-10-09)

41. 2021-04-20

On April 20, 2021, a Minneapolis jury found former officer Derek Chauvin guilty on all three charges in George Floyd's death: second-degree murder, third-degree murder and second-degree manslaughter.

- **Source:** Derek Chauvin convicted on all three counts over George Floyd killing (Cayman Compass); Derek Chauvin verdict reached in trial over George Floyd's death (NBC News)
- **In the posts:** How can I help? (2021-05-13); I hope you choose that path, no matter how hard it is (2021-04-20); Des Moines, Police and Protest (2021-04-09)

42. 2023-01-07

Tyre Nichols was beaten by Memphis police officers during an arrest on January 7, 2023, and died on January 10; five officers were fired and indicted on January 26, and video of the beating was released on January 27, 2023.

- **Source:** Memphis police release videos showing arrest and brutal beating of Tyre Nichols (KRDO)
- **In the posts:** Modern-Day Lynchings (2023-01-27); Confluence (2023-01-28); FCNL Statement on Anti-racism, Anti-bias, Justice, Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion (2023-02-04)

43. 2023-01-18

On January 18, 2023, police killed forest defender Manuel 'Tortuguita' Terán during a raid on a protest camp opposing Atlanta's planned $90 million, 85-acre police training center ('Cop City'); Gov. Brian Kemp then declared a state of emergency.

- **Source:** Protesters question circumstances surrounding 'Stop Cop City' activist's death (PBS NewsHour)
- **In the posts:** Modern-Day Lynchings (2023-01-27)

44. 2025-04-28

On April 28, 2025, Rev. William Barber II, Rev. Jonathan Wilson-Hartgrove and Steve Swayne were arrested while praying in the U.S. Capitol Rotunda against the Republican-led budget bill.

- **Source:** William Barber arrested after praying in Capitol Rotunda (Baptist Standard)
- **In the posts:** Rev William Barber arrested at US Capitol (2025-04-29)

45. Undated

The Kheprw Institute is an Indianapolis nonprofit focused on youth development and community wealth building; Imhotep Adisa is a co-founder and its executive director.

- **Source:** Kheprw Institute (Wikipedia); Imhotep Adisa (New America)

- **In the posts:** Quakers and social change today (2020-05-22); Quaker Social Change Ministry at North Meadow Friends (2016-02-02)

Not yet verified

These statements appear in the posts but could not be checked against an outside source during this pass. They are not confirmed and not shown to be wrong.

- On October 13, 2020, a coalition of 10 Iowa organizations led by the Des Moines Black Liberation Movement (formerly Des Moines Black Lives Matter) declared a 'Black State of Emergency' in Iowa. In the posts: Black State of Emergency in Iowa #BlackEmergencyIA; Des Moines, Police and Protest